organization meant to promote Sikh educational institutions in Punjab. It was presided over by a US national, Ganga Singh Dhillon, head of the Washington DC-based Guru Nanak Foundation. Though a comparatively unknown entity in Punjab till then, Ganga Singh Dhillon was close to some influential US senators and congressmen as well as to Pakistan's President Zia-ul-Haq.

During the proceedings of the Chandigarh conference, it was declared that 'Sikhs are a separate nation'. Dhillon himself moved a resolution stating, 'Sikhs be admitted as an associate member of the UN as they are not a part of Hindu mainstream and had a separate identity.' Following Dhillon's visit, senior BJP leader Atal Bihari Vajpayee, participating in a debate in the Lok Sabha, quoted Punjab Chief Minster Darbara Singh as having said that Zail Singh had met Ganga Singh Dhillon at Karnal. [2]

As late as on 10 August 1981, Indira Gandhi had said in a press conference at New Delhi, 'So far, Khalistan existed only in Canada and perhaps in the USA also, but it does not mean that we would lower our guards and not exercise the utmost vigilance.' [3] It would be pertinent to question – given Ganga Singh Dhillon's background – why he was allowed entry into the country to preside over such a conference in Chandigarh.

To compete with Bhindranwale's growing influence, in May 1981 the moderate Akali Dal leadership demanded a complete ban on the use of tobacco in the holy city of Amritsar. There were demonstrations and counter-demonstrations in support of and against this demand. Akalis even shouted some provocative slogans against the Hindu Suraksha Samiti (HSS) led by Patiala-based Pawan Kumar Sharma, who had organized demonstrations against this demand.

Pawan Kumar was reportedly close to Amarinder Singh and Haryana chief minster Bhajan Lal. Lala Jagat Narain and a section of Congress leaders had also supported the HSS on that issue. After the anti-tobacco demonstrations of 31 May 1981 at Amritsar, the Punjab government asked people to surrender their licensed arms. Bhindranwale, addressing a congregation at Sector 11, Gurudwara Chandigarh, was adamant that his men would not surrender their arms.